

NSAID Stomach Protection: When You Need a PPI

Co-prescribed omeprazole isn't just routine — it prevents serious bleeds.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
2026-06-15 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Co-prescribed omeprazole isn't just routine — it prevents serious bleeds.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Arthritis UK consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- ****Talk to your clinician.**** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- ****Track your symptoms.**** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- ****Move within comfort.**** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/conditions/osteoarthritis\)](#).
 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment.
 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.
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Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team from UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. Pending clinical review. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Systematic reviews of many randomised controlled trials consistently show that combining a proton pump inhibitor (PPI) like omeprazole with non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs) significantly reduces the risk of gastrointestinal side effects. These unpleasant and sometimes dangerous effects include stomach ulcers and bleeding. Clinical guidelines from leading medical bodies across the UK strongly recommend this co-prescription for individuals at increased risk, highlighting it as a crucial protective measure.

The evidence particularly supports this approach for those with a history of stomach problems, older adults, and those taking other medications that can thin the blood. While individual patient circumstances always guide treatment decisions, the overall picture from robust research is clear: PPIs offer vital protection when taking NSAIDs long-term or at higher doses.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Stopping your PPI too soon:** Always follow your doctor's instructions for the full course. * **Taking your PPI only when you feel symptoms:** It's a preventative medication, not a pain reliever. * **Assuming all stomach pain is standard:** New or severe pain needs urgent medical attention. * **Doubling up on doses:** Stick to the prescribed amount to avoid potential side effects. * **Not telling your doctor about ALL your medications:** Drug interactions can increase risks.

When to Speak to a Clinician

It's important to monitor your health closely when taking NSAIDs and PPIs. Don't hesitate to contact your GP, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist if you experience any new concerning symptoms, or if your existing symptoms worsen.

* Sudden, severe stomach pain or cramping. * Black, tarry stools, or blood in your vomit. * Unexplained weight loss or loss of appetite. * New or persistent indigestion, heartburn, or abdominal discomfort. * Feeling unusually tired, dizzy, or short of breath, which could indicate bleeding.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can I stop taking my PPI if I no longer take NSAIDs? It is generally safe to stop your PPI once you stop taking NSAIDs, unless your doctor has prescribed it for another condition. Always discuss this with your doctor first to ensure it's appropriate for your individual health situation.

Are there any long-term side effects of taking omeprazole? Most people tolerate omeprazole well, but long-term use can sometimes be associated with certain issues like nutrient deficiencies or an increased risk of specific infections. Your doctor will weigh these potential risks against the benefits of preventing serious stomach complications.

What if I forget to take my omeprazole dose? If you miss a dose, take it as soon as you remember. However, if it's almost time for your next dose, skip the missed one and continue with your regular schedule. Do not take a double dose to make up for a forgotten one.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about nsaid stomach protection: when you need a ppi?

Short answer: Combining a proton pump inhibitor (PPI) like omeprazole with non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs (NSAIDs) significantly reduces the risk of gastrointestinal side effects including stomach ulcers and bleeding. This co-prescription is recommended for individuals at increased risk, such as those with a history of stomach problems, older adults, and those taking blood-thinning medications. PPIs offer vital protection when taking NSAIDs long-term or at higher doses.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk